

QMS SOP TEMPLATE:

Product Quality Complaints

Quality
Management
System
Standard
Operating
Procedure



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Introduction

All complaints received by any means of communication should be properly documented and assessed to determine if they represent a potential quality defect or any other quality issue.

As comprehensive information on the nature and extent of the quality defect may not always be available at the early stages of an investigation, the decision-making processes should still ensure that appropriate risk-reducing actions are taken at an appropriate timepoint during such investigations.

Proper documentation of the process followed during the investigation, including all the decisions and corrective actions taken as a result of the quality defect shall be part of the complaint management process.

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1.0 Purpose

The purpose of this procedure is to describe the methodology used behind the process of complaint handling, from initiating, investigating, evaluating, establishing corrective actions, closing, and trending quality complaints.

2.0 Scope

This procedure applies to all complaints received from customers, distributors, or internal personnel regarding pharmaceutical products (including clinical studies) manufactured and released to the market by the manufacturing site.

3.0 Definitions/Abbreviations

Complaint: Any real or perceived problem with the physical characteristics, durability or performance of the product (marketed or investigational) or its packaging to include a different taste or smell, discoloration, broken, missing safety seal, etc.

Confirmed Complaint: A complaint disposition where the record review reveals an unidentified or unresolved deviation or where both the complaint field sample and retain sample exhibit out-of-specification (OOS) results and the investigation has verified that the defect referenced by the complaint is due to conditions of processing or testing operations.

Unconfirmed Complaint: A complaint disposition where the record review confirms no unidentified or unresolved deviations or when only the field sample exhibits OOS results and the investigation verified that the defect is present on the return sample, but the source could not be verified or caused by the product manufacturing site.

4.0 Responsibilities

Quality Assurance/Qualified Person:

- Responsible for executing the requirement outlined in this procedure
- Assess the initial complaint and oversee additional actions to be taken, such as informing the Competent Authorities

All employees:

- Reporting any product complaint as per this procedure

Complaint Coordinator:

- Initiate, evaluate, review, and close complaint investigations
- Administer the process, track timelines and compile metrics, organize meetings to review complaints, communicate with customer/complainant during the investigation process (including the collection of field samples, when available)
- Initiate CAPAs as required by the complaint investigation
- Establish and document a Risk Assessment as required
- Summarize complaint information, present the complaint metrics to Senior Management

Functional Areas:

- Support the complaint investigation and help establish corrective actions when applicable
- Review and approve the complaint investigation

Quality Head:

- Provide guidance and support for complaint investigations when required
- Ensure requirements of this procedure are implemented and adhered to within the investigation
- Review and approve critical complaint investigations

5.0 Requirements

- Any complaint received by an employee shall be forwarded to Quality Assurance/Qualified Person within one (1) business day of receipt
- The complaint investigation shall be initiated within one (1) business day from the date of notification
- Complaints need to be investigated, assessed and closed within 30 business days from the date of initiation
- A complaint investigation number shall be assigned by registering the complaint to a designated logbook or electronically generated
- All field samples shall be logged into the Complaint Field Sample Logbook
 - A visual inspection of each field sample shall be performed, recording the description of the sample and their condition. Whenever possible, the lot number and each component of the sample shall be identified
 - When required, a field sample photograph of a sample may be sent to the contract organization supporting the investigation
 - If a field sample is sent off-site for any reason, the Complaint Field Sample Logbook shall be updated to reflect the status of the sample
 - Field samples shall be preserved for the duration of the investigation and may not be discarded prior to closure of the complaint investigation report
- When required, a complaint investigation shall be divided into two phases: (1) a documentation review and (2) laboratory analysis:
 - Documentation review

The following, at a minimum, shall be considered when conducting a documentation review:

- > Related manufacturing and packaging documents
- > A review of the complaint files shall determine if the same complaint occurred elsewhere in the lot or if a non-conformance was found during production, which may provide an explanation for the existing complaint.

- > The product testing history, including testing of stability and retain samples
- > Any component or product non-conformance
- > A review of similar complaints within the same lot or for the same or similar products.
- Laboratory Analysis
 - > Quality Control may analyze the complaint field sample (most likely exposed to dynamic environmental conditions) and a suitable retain sample (maintained under static environmental conditions), depending on the nature of the complaint, per the applicable product specifications
 - > If a complaint field sample was not provided by the customer/complainant, the laboratory investigation shall be limited to the retain sample testing
- Upon completing the documentation review and receiving the analytical results, Quality Assurance/Qualified Person shall complete the investigation and establish a conclusion regarding the complaint: (1) Confirmed, or (2) Unconfirmed.

6.0 Risks/Points of Attention

- The decisions that are made, during and following quality defect investigations, should reflect the level of risk that is presented by the quality defect as well as the seriousness of any non-compliance with respect to the requirements of the marketing authorization/product specification file or GMP. Such decisions should be timely to ensure that patient and animal safety is maintained, in a way that is commensurate with the level of risk that is presented by those issues.
- Quality defects should be investigated and reported in a timely manner by the manufacturer to the marketing authorization holder/sponsor and all concerned Competent Authorities in cases where the quality defect may result in the recall of the product or in an abnormal restriction in the supply of the product.
- Special attention should be given to establishing whether a suspected quality defect relates to falsification.
- Any complaint that does not indicate a potential quality defect should be fully documented and communicated to the relevant group or person responsible for the investigation and management of complaints of that nature, such as suspected adverse events.

7.0 Summary/Flowchart

- 7.1 *Initiating a Product Quality Complaint***
- 7.2 *Initial Assessment by Quality Assurance/Qualified Person***
- 7.3 *Reply to Complainant***
- 7.4 *Further Investigations***
- 7.5 *Final Reply to Complainant***
- 7.6 *Approving and Closing a Product Quality Complaint***

8.0 Procedure

8.1 *Initiating a Product Quality Complaint*

Upon receipt, Quality Assurance/QP shall assess the complaint to determine its impact on product and patient safety and determine if a notification to a Regulatory Authority is required.

8.1.1 If notification is required. Senior Management shall be informed

8.1.2 Notification to Regulatory Authorities shall be performed in accordance with Product Recall SOP.

8.1.3 Initiate the Product Quality Complaint Investigation Report within one (1) business day of receiving. A number shall be assigned by registering the complaint into a Product Quality Complaint logbook.

The Product Quality Complaint investigation Report shall be initiated within one (1) business day of receipt, a Complaint number shall be assigned and the following information should be documented:

- The person who initiated the complaint, including how and when, and the contact data of this person
- The employee who initially received the complaint and when
- A description of the reported quality defect, if possible with pictures, drawings, etc.

8.2 *Initial Assessment by Quality Assurance/Qualified Person*

After this initial documentation has been performed, an initial determination of the severity and extent of the possible quality defect takes place, within 24 hours after receipt.

Note: This is performed by the Quality Assurance/Qualified Person, in order to initiate immediate follow-up actions in case of possible falsification, potential serious defects or serious adverse events. In case of a possible adverse event, the Adverse Event Manager is notified and actions for further investigation are defined together.

8.3 *Reply to Complainant*

As soon as possible, but at least within three (3) business days, a reply is made to the complainant, with preliminary advice, if available at that time.

8.4 *Further Investigations*

The validity and extent of all reported quality defects should be assessed and documented in accordance with Quality Risk Management principles in order to support decisions regarding the degree of investigation and action taken.

Further investigation may include:

- Checking or testing of reference and/or retention samples
- A review of the batch production record, the batch certification record and the batch distribution records (especially for temperature-sensitive products)
- Requesting a sample, or the return, of the defective product from the complainant and, where a sample is provided, an appropriate evaluation of this material

- A review of previous quality defect reports or any other relevant information for any indication of specific or recurring problems requiring attention and possibly further regulatory action
- If a quality defect is discovered or suspected in a batch, consideration should be given to checking other batches and in some cases other products, in order to determine whether they are also affected. In particular, other batches which may contain portions of a defective batch or defective components should be investigated
- In case no quality defect is discovered, and the complaint might be the results of a possible adverse event, the Adverse Event Manager is immediately notified and actions for any other further investigation are defined
- An assessment of the impact that any recall action may have on the availability of the medicinal product to patients/animals in any affected market, and the need to notify the relevant authorities of such impact

8.5 Complaint Closure

Final conclusions are made during closure of the complaint relating to:

- The risk(s) posed by the quality defect, based on the severity and extent of the quality defect
- The potential need for risk-reducing actions to be taken in the distribution network, such as batch or product recalls, or any other activities
- The internal and external communications that should be made in relation to a quality defect and its investigation
- The identification of the potential root cause(s) of the quality defect
- The need for appropriate Corrective and Preventive Actions (CAPAs) to be identified and implemented for the issue including related due dates, and for the assessment of the effectiveness of those CAPAs

The information reported in relation to possible quality defects should be recorded and referred and attached to the Complaint Form, including all the original details and minutes of related meetings.

8.5.1 Confirmed Complaint

A complaint may be considered confirmed, when the record review reveals an unidentified or unresolved deviation which may have contributed to the complaint, or both the complaint field sample and the retain samples exhibit out-of-specification or non-compliant result.

A complaint may also be considered confirmed when only the retain sample or the field sample/return exhibit an OOS result, but it is evidently a one-time, unexplained product event.

8.5.2 Unconfirmed Complaint

A complaint is unconfirmed when one or more of the following occurs:

- The review of the record confirms no unidentified or unresolved deviations that may have contributed to the problem.
- Both the field sample and the retain sample present analytical results that are within specification or when only the field sample exhibits OOS results which may not be considered a single, unexplained product event.

This type of complaint may be classified as unconfirmed, as it did not occur because of a quality deviation in the retain sample but as a result of mishandling of the product after leaving the manufacturing site or mishandling of the field/return sample.

8.5.3 *Corrective Actions*

For all confirmed complaints, a corrective action shall be implemented.

These corrective actions may range from a simple training of employees to a formal corrective action and preventive action (CAPA) plan as described in the CAPA process SOP.

The criterion for choosing the appropriate corrective action shall depend on the nature of the complaint

- If a quality issue is discovered within a specific lot, it shall be determined whether that issue is present in other lots.
- Additionally, it shall be established if a reasonable probability exists that the use or exposure to the product in question may result in permanent injury, be life threatening or may lead to death or to a temporary, but medically reversible health problem.
 - In these cases, a recall shall be initiated as outlined in the Product Recall Management SOP.

Concerning non-confirmed complaints originating from misuse of inadequate handling of the drug product, even if there is no need for an internal corrective action, a written response shall be issued to provide orientation to the customer.

Regarding complaints resulting from counterfeit or adulterated drug product, a response letter shall be issued to the complainant; however, Senior Management shall be consulted concerning the need for further action.

After the completion of a Product Quality Complaint investigation, Quality Assurance shall ensure that a CAPA has been initiated for any corrective actions not completed prior to the closure of the investigation.

Critical product quality investigations shall be approved by the Quality Head.

8.6 *Final Reply to Complainant or Field Action*

Quality Assurance shall draft a response letter to the complainant, detailing the investigation, the results obtained, and in the case that a complaint is confirmed, any possible implications which may arise as a result of the quality issue.

- If appropriate, surrogate product may be sent to the complainant together with the response letter, to replace the returned field sample.

The Quality Head shall determine if the complaint represents a serious and unexpected adverse drug experience, which may require it to be reported to a Regulatory Authority as outlined in the Product Recall Management SOP.

9.0 **Documentation of Results**

- All activities related to complaints are documented in a Complaint File, per complaint, using a standard Complaint Form as a basis.
- All complaints are logged in a Complaint logbook.

10.0 **References**

- 21 CFR Part 210 – Current Good Manufacturing Practice in Manufacturing, Processing, Packing, or Holding of Drugs; General
- 21 CFR Part 211 – Current Good Manufacturing Practice for Finished Pharmaceuticals

- 21 CFR Part 211.198 – Complaint Files
- 21 CFR Part 820 – Quality System Regulation (for Medical Devices)
- ISO 9001:2015 – Quality Management Systems
- ISO 13485:2016 – Medical Devices Quality Management Systems
- Pharmaceutical Inspection Co-operation Scheme. *PIC/S Guide to Good Manufacturing Practice for Medicinal Products: Part I (PE 009-17)*
- EU GMP Guide – Part I: Chapter 8 (Complaints, Quality Defects, and Production Recalls)
- TRS 986 – Annex 2: WHO Good Manufacturing Practices for Pharmaceutical Products: Main Principles

11.0 Revision History

- Rev 01 – Initial release
- Rev 02 – [To be updated with future changes]

12.0 Addenda

12.1 Addendum I: Complaint Base Form Example

Complaint Number (page 1)	0067	
Complaint Intake		
Source of complaint incl. name of complainant	Call and email from Medical Hospital London, Dr. J.D. Marsh	
Product Description	Starility 200 mg/vial – UK	
Batch number	12345	
Quantity affected	35 vials	
Description of complaint	Integrity of closure seems to be compromised, at least with two (2) vials, according to Dr. Marsh. All vials shipped are returned for further investigation	
Documentation attached?	Yes, see email Dr. J.D. Marsh, dd 26 JUN 2024 ASBU	
Complaint intake performed	By: Asha Burini	Date: 26 JUN 2024
Initial Assessment Quality Assurance/QP (within 24 hours after receipt)		
Quality Assurance/QP	Name: John Menno	Date: 26 JUN 2024
Investigation required?	Yes / No*	Signature: JMenno
*Investigation # or justification if investigation is not required	N/A	
Reply to Complainant (within three (3) working days after receipt)		
Reply to Complainant sent and attached	By: Asha Burini	Date: 28 JUN 2024

12.1 Addendum I: Complaint Base Form Example (continued)

Complaint Number (page 2)	0067	
Investigation Summary		
Is Complaint related to a Quality Defect?	Yes / No *	
*If No – notification of AE Manager on (date/ by)	N/A	
Risk(s) posed by Quality Defect:	<i>Possible breach of sterility by lack of vacuum.</i>	
Need for risk-reducing actions? Please define which:	<i>All vials of this batch 12345 are included in a recall (see Recall Form 24002). Fortunately, the 35 vials were the only ones delivered so far.</i>	
Internal and external communications sent out? (please attach)	<i>See attached for communication to Competent Authorities 27 JUN 2024 and memo to staff 27 JUN 2024</i>	
Root Cause defined	<i>Freeze dryer malfunction (FD-002)</i>	
CAPA's defined (add numbers)	<i>CAPA 11287 for complete servicing and repair of freeze dryer, including revalidation of FD-002</i>	
Minutes of all meetings (please attach)	<i>See attached minutes 27 JUN 2024</i>	
Complaint Closure (within 30 working days after receipt)		
Conclusion	<i>Product defect due to malfunctioning freeze dryer, complete batch has been recalled.</i>	
Complaint closed by Quality Assurance	Name: <i>John Menno</i>	Signature: <i>JMenno</i>
	Date: <i>01 JUL 2024</i>	
Final letter to complainant, Logbook entry closed	By: <i>MEHU</i>	Date: <i>01 JUL 2024</i>

12.2 Addendum II: Complaint Logbook Example

Complaint #	Date Received	Product Description	Quantity Affected	Batch #	Description of Complaint	Target Closure Date	Log Entry Date / By	Closure Date / By
0067	26 JUN 2024	Starility 200 mg/vial – UK	35 vials	12345	Integrity of closure seems compromised, no vacuum	01 JUL 2024	26 JUN 2024 ASBU	01 JUL 2024 MEHU
0068	29 JUN 2024	Stairwell 50 mg tablet, 30 pack – US	100,000 packs	22563	Wrong expiry date on pack 01 JUL 2027 instead of 01 JUL 2027	05 JUL 2024	30 JUN 2024 / ASBU	
0069								
0070								
0071								
0072								
0073								
0074								
0075								



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